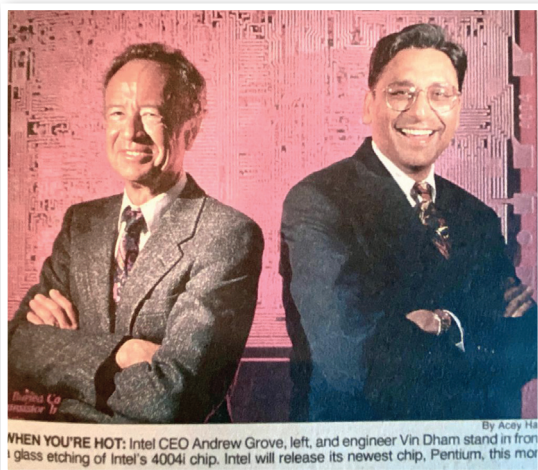




Intel CEO Andy Grove with Vinod Dham who lead Intel to the top with his leadership on 486 and Pentium processors

Nvidia, AMD, Broadcom, and Intel—offering thousands of jobs in electronics today, existed in India at that time. The word startup did not even exist in the vocabulary of India. The few companies that existed in this sector were either Philips, which was basically selling radios in India, or Televista, which used to make television, or one or two similar ones. So, I had only a few options. However, an invisible hand has always guided

me in my life. Somehow, I met a young man who was my brother's friend. He recommended my name to his company and, finally, I got a job."

Vinod began his career with Delhi based semiconductor (transistors and diodes) manufacturer Continental Devices India Limited, one of India's only private silicon semiconductor companies at that time, who had collaborated with Teradyne Semiconductor Company, USA. The company was established in 1969 by Gurpreet Singh, an alumnus of the London School of Economics.

While remembering Gurpreet Singh, Vinod mentions Singh's hosting Robert Noyce, the co-founder of Intel, at his home. He recalls, "The saddest story Sardarji told me was that he took Intel founder in 1969-70 to the then Department of Electronics, Government of India, as he wanted to start building chips in India. However, the Indian government told Bob Noyce that he could build only 200,000 chips per year. We all know, that a fab produces millions of chips per year! Moreover, it is ridiculous to put a limit on chip production, because the more you make, the cheaper you make, and the better you make.

"Bob Noyce went to Hong Kong to build a factory and India missed

the semicon opportunity just because of the *license raj* or an inappropriate regulatory environment in India. We missed the bus in a big way, for a long time. I was hurt to learn this little-known tidbit about how we missed an opportunity. Had we capitalised on it then, it would have put India ahead of Taiwan and China, and we would have been one of the foremost countries along with the US."

Building a professional life

At Continental Devices, Vinod was a part of the early team that put together a facility in Naraina Industrial Area, New Delhi, and worked there for four years. While he worked at this company, his love for semiconductors grew further. He found the subject quite interesting and felt that he needed a deeper understanding of the physics behind the behavior of the semiconductor devices. This quest for learning prompted him to pursue higher studies.

In 1975, Vinod left Continental Devices to pursue an MS degree in solid-state physics from the University of Cincinnati, in Ohio. This decision was prompted by the suggestion of S.S. Madan, the then general manager of Continental Devices. He was a semiconductors expert who had returned to India after spending many years working for Philips Semiconductors in Holland. "This turned out to be the second game-changing decision of my life," Vinod explains.

Back in 1975, the government of India used to allow only eight dollars as foreign currency to the Indians go-

"I think entrepreneurship is probably the most challenging job, as there are nine hundred and ninety-nine reasons for failure. If you still want to succeed, you have to be a little bit crazy to do this. But if you succeed, it's very exhilarating and rewarding. Once you have tasted the fruits of entrepreneurial success, you will never go back to being anybody but your own boss, pursuing new ideas, and backing innovative startups."

—Vinod Dham

surprised to outdo those I was afraid were way ahead of me. This helped build my confidence sky-high. I felt I could climb the ladder of life as successfully as anybody else. That was really a game changer for me!"

Vinod broke the stereotype of a good student repeatedly throughout his educational life. For example, he did not attend classes that were not interesting enough for him. He remembers one instance where his professor made a joke of him by saying, "Mr Dham, you're early for the next class," when Vinod attempted to enter the class towards the end.

However, the impact of not attending classes went far beyond the joke as Vinod had to face the same professor in the final examination. In spite of all his answers being correct, he received poor marks. The professor explained that Vinod did not deserve good marks because of his poor attendance. He says, "See, I was not judged on merit or knowledge, I was judged based on my lack of discipline for not attending classes. So, this has stuck with me and I actually use it as a lesson in my life."

Soon after completing his engineering degree in 1971, Vinod began his professional journey. He mentions, "Believe it or not, none of the big Indian companies like TCS or Wipro—or similar multinationals like